Abu Daoud, a leader of the Black September group, collaborating with the PLO. Although the GDR condemned the Munich murders, the PLO's charismatic leader Yasser Arafat sought to soothe nerves in a letter to Honecker sent eleven days after the massacre. In it, he urged 'understanding of the action in Munich from the viewpoint of the general problem and its historical events with all of their political, national and human dimensions'.2

Arafat found a sympathetic ear. In his reply, Honecker expressed enthusiasm for the Arab-Palestinian people and riled at Israeli 'acts of aggression' against Lebanon and Syria. Remarkably, as the shadows cast by Arab terror darkened Europe's security situation, Honecker's links with Libya, Syria and the PLO were strengthened. Arafat received an impressive reception in Berlin the following year when installed at the stucco Schönhausen Palace as a VIP state guest, where he spent afternoons strolling in the stately garden. As it turned out, the Palestinian was impressed by Honecker's grasp of the Middle East conflict and later claimed all PLO accomplishments were 'achieved with the help of the GDR, thanks to its influence in the world'.3

Soon, everything was in place for the PLO to open a consular office in East Berlin. On 29 March 1973, two years after their first encounter, Honecker graciously accepted more words of homage from Arafat, who wrote:

We are proud of your attitude, which is an expression of the indivisibility of the struggle our people are waging against imperialism, Zionism, racial hatred, occupation and colonialism in all its forms. I assure you and all comrades that we will continue the fight until the freedom and independence of our people and all peoples has become a reality.

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